

The Mitsue Model: Forest Restoration, Energy, and Data Centers

"The forest our ancestors planted — powering the village they built." 先人が植えた森が、今、村に豊かさをもたらす。

This powerful triad—**forest restoration**, **distributed energy**, and **community-owned data centers**—is a highly innovative model for revitalizing rural Japan. By aligning local environmental needs with cutting-edge tech infrastructure, depopulated towns can cultivate a circular economy that attracts investment and green jobs. [\[1, 2, 3\]](#)

The Mechanics of the Model

- **Forest Restoration:** Rural Japan suffers from neglected and overgrown cedar and cypress plantations. Municipalities are using the [Forest Management System](#) to consolidate land management, clear overgrowth, and harvest timber. [\[1, 2, 3, 4, 5\]](#)
- **Distributed Energy:** The biomass harvested during forest thinning is used as fuel for local, decentralized biomass power plants. These plants, combined with small-scale solar and wind, provide a localized grid that stabilizes rural energy supplies. [\[1, 2\]](#)
- **Community-Owned Data Center:** Computing facilities are built directly adjacent to these localized, renewable energy sources. Because data centers require vast amounts of power and cooling, locating them in rural, cool mountainous areas (using ambient air for cooling) drastically lowers operational costs and the carbon footprint. [\[1\]](#)

Why This Works for Rural Japan

1. **The Circular Economy:** Clearing the forests generates wood/biomass energy. This energy runs the data center, which can also process local data (e.g., agricultural IoT, AI forestry monitoring). The revenue and taxes generated stay within the community. [\[1\]](#)
2. **Repopulation & Jobs:** It shifts the economic base from traditional agriculture/forestry to a high-tech "green" sector, creating IT and engineering jobs that attract younger demographics to the countryside. [\[1, 2\]](#)
3. **Decentralization from Tokyo:** This supports the national goal of correcting the over-concentration of resources in the Tokyo metropolitan area by turning rural regions into self-sustaining technological and ecological hubs. [\[1\]](#)

There are already pioneering examples of this taking shape in Japan, such as the *Soya Green Data Center* in Wakkanai, Hokkaido, which directly connects wind power to a data center, and woody biomass circular systems in towns like Mishima, Fukushima. [\[1, 2\]](#)

If you are exploring a specific project or region, I can:

- Detail the **grants and subsidies** currently available through the national government.
- Provide case studies of **specific municipalities** executing these exact goals.
- Estimate the **scale/MW capacity** needed to support a community data center. [\[1, 2\]](#)